

ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · April 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	76.5
#2	A+	Salt Lake City	73.7
#3	A+	Oklahoma City	70.0
#4	A+	Nashville	68.3
#5	A	Pittsburgh	66.9
#6	A	Hartford	66.3
#7	A-	Austin	62.3

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Sacramento	21.1
#49	D	Detroit	21.8
#48	C-	San Francisco	27.7
#47	C-	San Diego	29.4
#46	C-	Orlando	30.4
#45	C	San Jose	33.4
#44	C	Portland	33.5

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	12 cities
B+ / B / B-	20 cities
C+ / C / C-	16 cities
D	2 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, LFP, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · April 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	76.5	3.0%	+4.5%	+1.2%	67.7%	46 days
2	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	73.7	3.4%	+3.1%	+1.8%	72.8%	45 days
3	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	A+	70.0	3.6%	+4.7%	+0.5%	65.7%	55 days
4	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A+	68.3	3.0%	+1.6%	+1.0%	76.3%	53 days
5	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	A	66.9	3.6%	+8.7%	+1.1%	60.3%	65 days
6	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	66.3	2.7%	-0.4%	+1.9%	64.7%	39 days
7	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	62.3	3.2%	+3.2%	+0.7%	74.0%	53 days
8	Richmond Richmond	A-	62.3	3.3%	+5.1%	+0.3%	64.2%	39 days
9	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	A-	60.5	2.5%	+5.1%	+0.1%	66.9%	51 days
10	Columbus Columbus	A-	60.0	3.6%	+0.9%	+1.2%	65.6%	41 days
11	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	A-	59.2	3.5%	+4.5%	+0.9%	66.3%	54 days
12	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	A-	59.1	3.6%	+6.6%	+0.1%	70.4%	38 days
13	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B+	57.1	3.3%	+8.3%	-0.0%	64.6%	N/A
14	Memphis Memphis	B+	56.1	4.0%	+6.2%	+0.1%	60.5%	62 days
15	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B+	55.9	3.5%	+7.1%	+0.2%	62.5%	74 days
16	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	54.3	4.0%	+2.2%	+1.2%	64.0%	43 days
17	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	B	53.3	3.1%	+3.4%	-0.1%	62.7%	45 days
18	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B	53.0	3.6%	+3.1%	+0.3%	69.6%	48 days
19	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	52.6	4.2%	+2.6%	+0.4%	64.5%	50 days
20	Kansas City Kansas City	B	52.6	3.5%	+6.8%	-0.3%	67.9%	45 days
21	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	B	52.2	3.6%	-1.5%	+2.7%	65.4%	49 days
22	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	B	50.7	3.7%	+1.8%	+1.1%	62.8%	61 days
23	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B	50.1	4.8%	+5.3%	+1.8%	63.6%	45 days
24	Birmingham Birmingham	B-	49.4	N/A	-0.1%	+0.6%	60.6%	56 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
25	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	B-	48.5	4.0%	+3.1%	+0.5%	63.9%	44 days
26	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	48.2	4.5%	+4.8%	+0.5%	63.3%	51 days
27	St. Louis St. Louis	B-	47.1	3.5%	+0.7%	-0.0%	65.3%	46 days
28	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	46.8	3.9%	+1.4%	+0.7%	68.5%	30 days
29	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	46.7	4.6%	+4.9%	+0.9%	60.0%	66 days
30	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	45.3	5.0%	+7.6%	-0.1%	68.2%	34 days
31	Jacksonville Jacksonville	B-	45.0	4.6%	+5.0%	+0.7%	60.4%	58 days
32	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	B-	44.3	4.0%	+0.0%	+0.6%	69.0%	36 days
33	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	44.0	4.3%	+3.6%	+0.6%	50.8%	48 days
34	Cleveland Cleveland	C+	43.6	3.4%	-1.8%	+0.6%	58.0%	55 days
35	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C+	39.7	3.8%	+1.4%	-1.6%	67.4%	30 days
36	Fresno Fresno	C+	39.4	8.2%	+7.6%	+0.2%	60.3%	51 days
37	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C+	39.0	4.5%	+2.8%	+0.6%	64.8%	35 days
38	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C+	39.0	3.6%	+1.2%	-0.1%	64.2%	37 days
39	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	C+	39.0	5.2%	+6.7%	-0.8%	65.0%	52 days
40	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	39.0	3.1%	+3.7%	-0.9%	63.2%	33 days
41	Cincinnati Cincinnati	C	37.0	3.6%	+1.5%	-0.5%	63.1%	45 days
42	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C	36.2	3.6%	+10.2%	-1.3%	59.0%	36 days
43	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	35.3	5.1%	+7.5%	+0.2%	60.4%	54 days
44	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	33.5	4.9%	+4.8%	-0.7%	66.2%	49 days
45	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	C	33.4	4.0%	+0.6%	-0.2%	64.3%	24 days
46	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	C-	30.4	4.4%	+0.4%	+0.2%	64.0%	67 days
47	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C-	29.4	4.4%	+2.4%	+0.3%	62.0%	38 days
48	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	C-	27.7	4.1%	+0.5%	-0.5%	64.5%	29 days
49	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	D	21.8	4.7%	-1.1%	+0.0%	61.3%	45 days
50	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	D	21.1	4.8%	+2.5%	-0.3%	60.1%	39 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

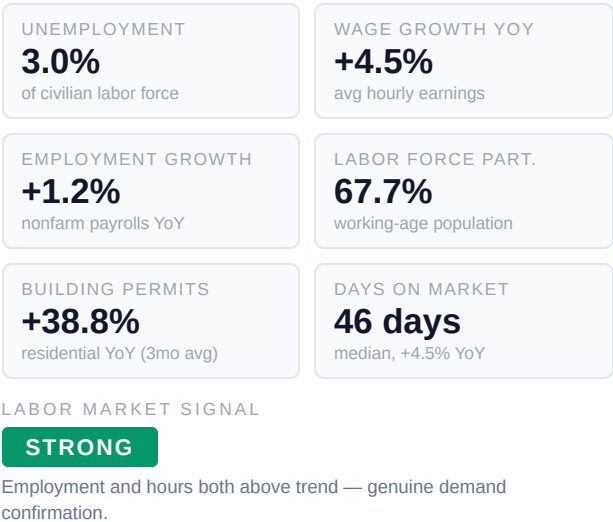
76.5th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Raleigh's A+ overall grade is driven by its exceptionally tight labor market, with a 3.00% unemployment rate and a 67.67% labor force participation rate, making it a highly competitive hiring environment. This environment poses significant challenges for businesses in attracting and retaining top talent.

Raleigh's job growth is strong, with nonfarm employment increasing by 1.25% year-over-year, indicating a healthy and expanding economy. However, the city's housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 4.5% year-over-year, which could stabilize the market given the strong employment growth and aggressive housing supply expansion, with building permits rising by 38.82% year-over-year.

Raleigh offers a highly skilled and engaged workforce, ranking in the 96th percentile for professional workforce concentration. However, the intense competition for labor may drive up wages and recruitment costs, posing a primary risk for businesses. Overall, Raleigh is an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses and HQ locations, but companies must be prepared to navigate a highly competitive labor market.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A+

EXCELLENT

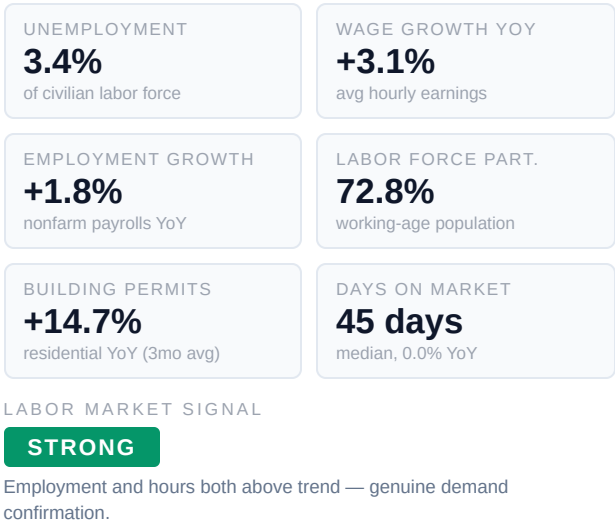
73.7th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Salt Lake City earns an A+ grade, driven by its exceptional economic character, with a low unemployment rate of 3.40% and a high labor force participation rate of 72.77%, indicating a deep and engaged workforce. The city's nonfarm employment growth is a remarkable 1.83% year-over-year, signaling rapid job creation and an economically expanding market.

The city's office and professional worker share ranks in the 98th percentile, indicating a deep pool of specialized talent. However, the housing market is highly competitive, with days on market at 45 days, and no year-over-year change, posing a challenge for relocating workers.

Salt Lake City offers businesses a thriving labor market with access to a deep and skilled workforce, making it an ideal location for knowledge-economy businesses. However, the city's highly competitive housing market may pose a risk for talent attraction and retention, as relocating workers may face significant challenges in securing housing quickly and affordably.

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

A+

EXCELLENT

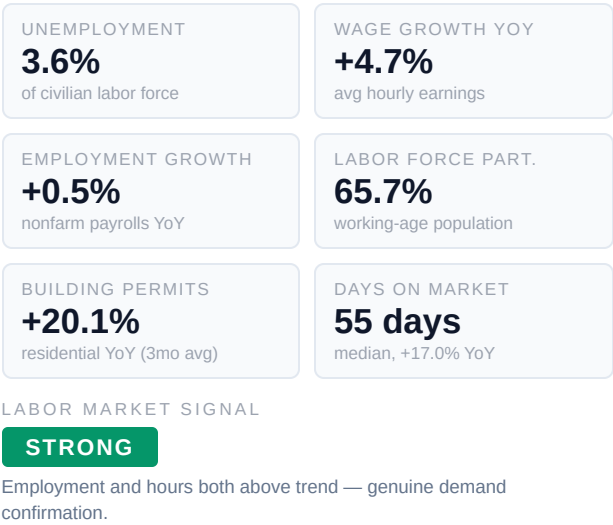
70.0th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City earns an A+ grade, driven by its exceptional economic performance, with a strong labor market and above-average nonfarm employment growth of +0.52% YoY and solid wage growth of +4.70% YoY. This healthy expansion is likely to support consumer spending.

The city's cost of living composite score of 1.27 ranks it among the most affordable metros, offering a significant cost advantage for businesses and residents. Meanwhile, building permits are growing at an above-average rate of +20.14% YoY, indicating that housing supply is keeping pace with demand. However, the days on market have increased by +17.0% YoY to 55 days, suggesting a slowing market.

Oklahoma City presents a unique combination of a strong labor market, affordable cost of living, and a stabilizing housing market, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the potential for the housing market to continue slowing remains a key risk, which could impact demand and affordability if not managed carefully.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A+

EXCELLENT

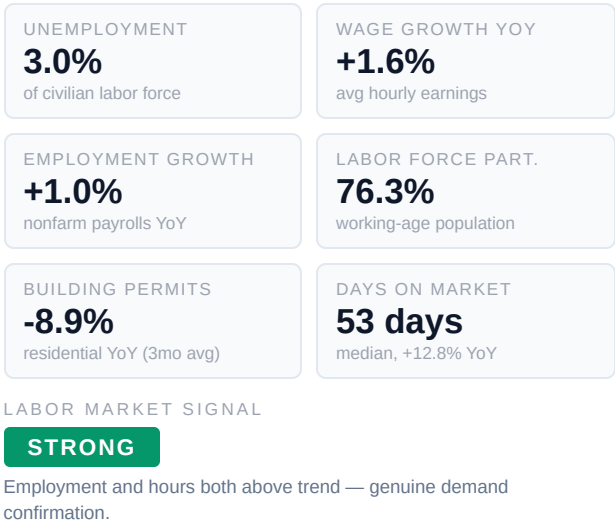
68.3th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville's A+ overall grade is driven by its exceptional labor market, with a 3.0% unemployment rate and 76.27% labor force participation, indicating a deep and engaged workforce. The city's 1.03% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth solidifies its position as an economically expanding market, with rapid job creation driving momentum.

While Nashville's labor market is highly competitive, with a 92nd percentile office and professional worker share, wage growth has been sluggish, with hourly earnings increasing by only 1.62% year-over-year. This may signal weak worker bargaining power or softening demand. The housing market is also moderating, with days on market increasing by 12.8% year-over-year to an average of 53 days.

Nashville offers businesses a highly skilled and engaged workforce, as well as a thriving economy with rapid job creation, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to tap into a deep talent pool. However, the intense competition for labor may drive up costs and create challenges for businesses looking to hire and retain top talent.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

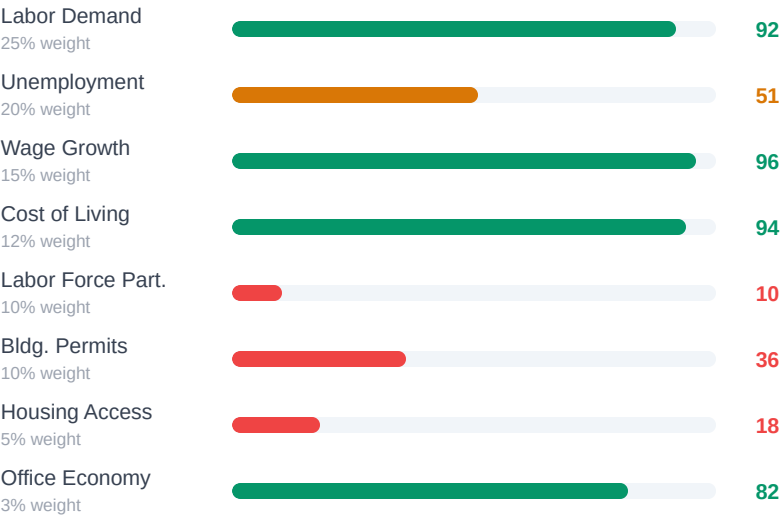
A

VERY GOOD

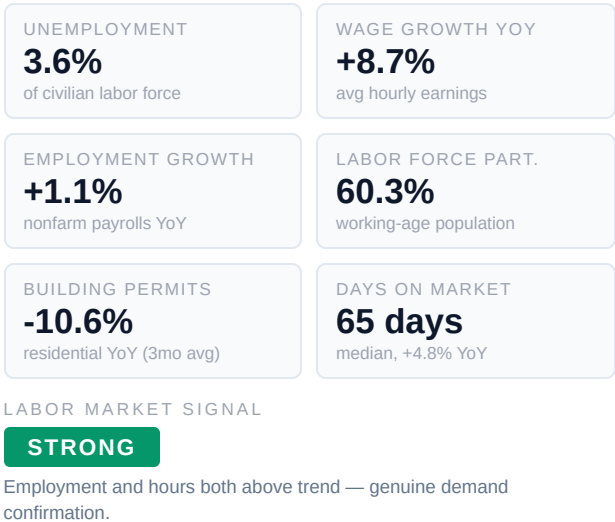
66.9th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh's economy is characterized by rapid job creation, with nonfarm employment growth at +1.07% year-over-year, driven by a highly skilled workforce, as evidenced by its top-tier office and professional worker share. The city's extremely affordable cost of living, with a composite index score of 1.11, makes it one of the most affordable metros in the dataset, further fueling this growth.

However, this growth comes with cost pressures, as wage growth is rising fast at +8.65% year-over-year, which may impact labor costs for employers. Labor force participation is critically low at 60.33%, which may constrain workforce availability and limit the city's ability to sustain its current growth trajectory.

Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of affordability, skilled workforce, and economic momentum, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses and HQ locations. However, the primary risk is the potential for labor market constraints and affordability pressures, particularly if the housing market continues to slow and labor force participation remains low, which could erode the city's cost advantage and limit its long-term growth potential.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

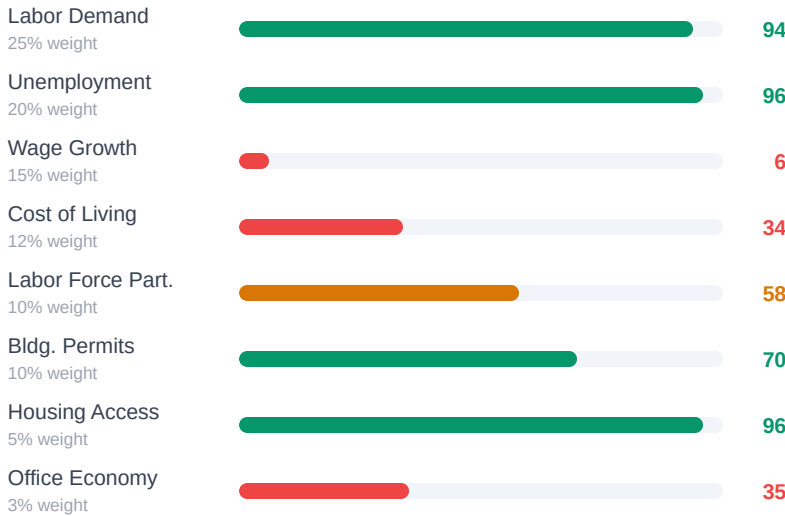
A

VERY GOOD

66.3th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

2.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-0.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.9%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.7%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+16.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days

median, +30.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Hartford's A grade, ranking in the 66.3rd percentile out of 50 US metros, is driven by its exceptionally tight labor market, with an unemployment rate of 2.70% and rapid job creation, as evidenced by nonfarm employment growth of +1.88% year-over-year. This momentum story is fueled by a highly competitive labor market, where businesses face significant hiring competition and workers have leverage. The city's strong employment growth and low unemployment rate make it an attractive location for businesses.

However, there are tensions in the data that deserve attention. Despite the strong labor market, wage growth is stagnant, with hourly earnings declining by -0.36% year-over-year, a bottom-tier performance. This raises concerns about consumer spending and the potential for a softening market. The cost of living composite, at 3.37, is below average, but not exceptionally low, suggesting that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Hartford offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with strong employment growth, but with the caveat that wage growth is stagnant, which may impact consumer spending. The city's slowing housing market, with days on market increasing by 30.0% year-over-year, resulting in an average of 39 days on market, provides a stabilizing force, but businesses should be aware of the potential risks associated with a softening market.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A-

GOOD

62.3th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

74.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-29.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

53 days

median, +20.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Austin's economy earns an A- grade with a 62.3rd percentile ranking out of 50 US metros, driven by its exceptionally tight labor market, with an unemployment rate of 3.20%, and a deep labor pool, as evidenced by a labor force participation rate of 73.99%. This highly competitive hiring environment gives workers significant leverage. Austin also boasts one of the most affordable cost of living composites, with a score of 1.44, suggesting lower real-wage requirements and higher consumer purchasing power.

However, the city's housing market is experiencing a sharp decline, with building permits down 29.44% year-over-year, and homes taking 20.4% more days to sell than last year, with an average of 53 days on market. This slowdown, combined with weak employment growth, suggests demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization of the market.

Austin offers businesses a unique blend of a tight labor market, deep labor pool, and affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the primary risk lies in the city's housing supply constraints and potential demand erosion, which may ultimately impact workforce availability and affordability, making it crucial for businesses to carefully consider these factors in their location decision.

Richmond

Richmond

A-

GOOD

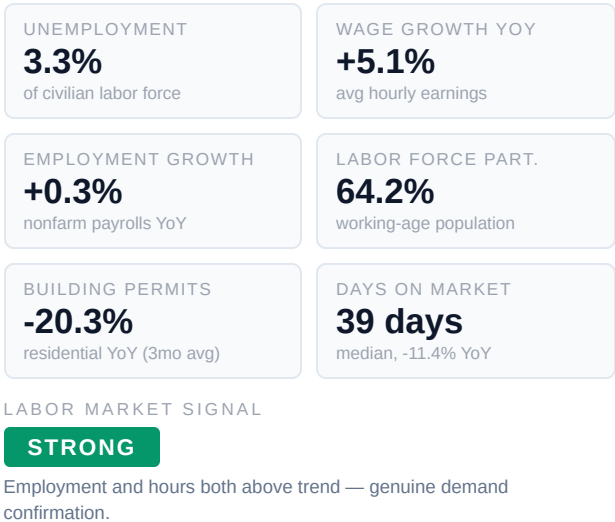
62.3th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Richmond's A- grade is driven by its exceptional labor market, with a 3.30% unemployment rate and 0.29% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, indicating a strong and expanding economy. This growth is accompanied by 5.12% year-over-year wage growth, suggesting a positive outlook for consumer spending.

However, beneath this positive surface, tensions emerge. The city's housing market is experiencing a severe supply contraction, with building permits plummeting by 20.27% year-over-year. Homes are selling in just 39 days on average, making it one of the fastest-moving markets in the dataset. This scenario raises concerns about affordability and workforce attraction, as new hires may face significant competition for limited housing options.

In summary, Richmond offers businesses a strong labor market with above-average growth, but the primary risk lies in its rapidly tightening housing market, which may deter talent and drive up costs.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

A-

GOOD

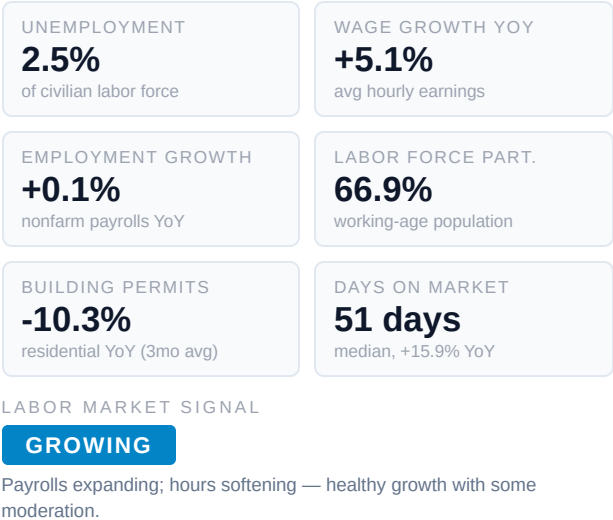
60.5th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Indianapolis earns an A- grade, driven by its exceptional labor market and attractive workforce profile, with a 2.50% unemployment rate and a 86th percentile ranking for office and professional worker share.

The city's strong labor market is accompanied by solid wage growth of 5.10% year-over-year, suggesting a positive outlook for consumer spending. However, this growth is tempered by a below-average nonfarm employment growth of 0.11% year-over-year, raising concerns about economic deceleration. The city's above-average cost of living composite score of 3.68 also indicates that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Indianapolis' slowing housing market, with a 15.9% year-over-year increase in days on market to an average of 51 days, is particularly concerning given the city's weak employment growth and average building permits. This slowdown demands careful consideration of talent acquisition and retention strategies to remain competitive in this market.

Columbus

Columbus

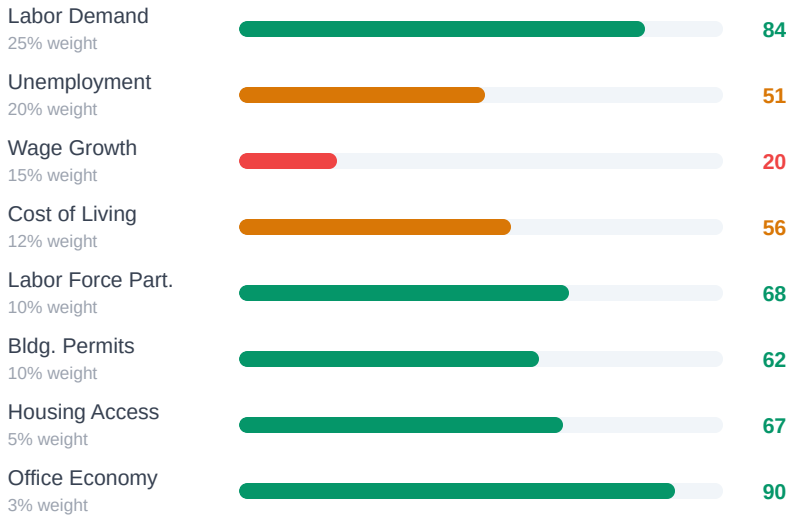
A-

GOOD

60.0th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.9%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

65.6%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+8.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

41 days

median, +10.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus earns an A- grade, driven by its strong economic momentum, with nonfarm employment growth of +1.17% YoY, ranking in the 84th percentile, and a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 90th percentile for office and professional worker share. The city's labor force participation rate of 65.61% indicates a readily available workforce.

Wage growth, at +0.86% YoY, ranks in the 20th percentile, suggesting weak worker bargaining power or softening demand. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 10.8% YoY to an average of 41 days, a relatively fast market. This slowdown may be a healthy normalization, given the strong employment growth and above-average building permits, up 8.67% YoY.

Columbus offers businesses a dynamic and expanding market with access to a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. However, the primary risk is the potential for labor market tightening, which could lead to increased competition for workers and upward pressure on wages, potentially eroding the current cost advantage.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

A-

GOOD

59.2th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area earns an A- grade, driven by a low 3.50% unemployment rate, 66.34% labor force participation rate, and 4.52% year-over-year wage growth. This strong labor market, with a top-tier ranking in office and professional worker share at the 88th percentile, provides a deep professional talent pool.

However, beneath this surface, nuances and tensions emerge. Nonfarm employment growth lags at +0.87% year-over-year, a risk signal worth watching. The days on market for homes are increasing by +5.9% year-over-year, indicating a slowing housing market. This trend, combined with below-average employment growth, suggests demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization.

Phoenix offers businesses a talented workforce, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a growing housing supply. However, the primary risk is demand erosion, driven by below-average employment growth, which could impact the city's long-term economic momentum.

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

A-

GOOD

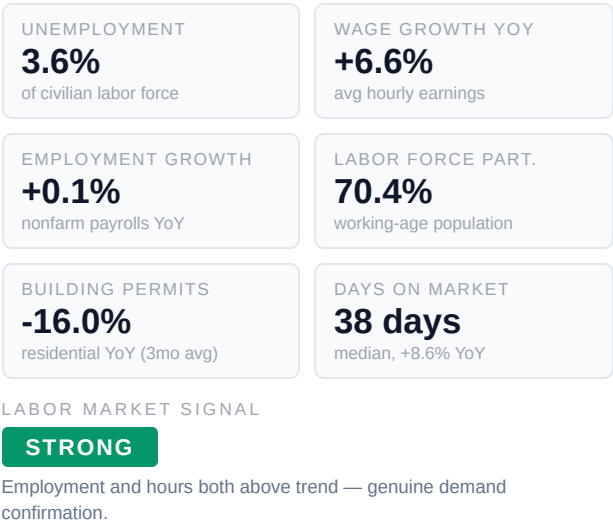
59.1th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Denver's economy earns a strong grade of A-, driven by its top-tier labor force participation rate of 70.39% and robust wage growth of 6.57% year-over-year, indicating a deep labor pool with engaged workers, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.46, below average, could be a draw for companies and employees alike.

However, the data reveals tensions. Despite the strong labor market, building permits have declined by 15.96% year-over-year, indicating a potential tightening of the housing supply. The days on market have increased by 8.6% year-over-year, with homes now taking an average of 38 days to sell. This slowing of the housing market could be a sign of demand erosion, particularly given the lackluster nonfarm employment growth of 0.13% year-over-year.

Denver offers businesses a talented and engaged workforce, as well as a relatively low cost of living. However, the primary risk is the potential for a tightening housing supply and slowing demand, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and make it less attractive to companies and employees in the long run.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.1th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



LABOR MARKET SIGNAL



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Atlanta's economy earns a B+ grade, ranking 57th among 50 US metros, with a single most important takeaway: its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.30% and rapid wage growth of 8.27% year-over-year indicate a tight labor market where workers have leverage. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.03 makes it one of the most affordable metros, a significant advantage for businesses looking to attract talent. Atlanta's exceptionally low unemployment rate and rapid wage growth suggest a tight labor market where workers have leverage.

However, beneath this surface, tensions emerge. The sharp decline in building permits, down 30.90% year-over-year, signals a contraction in housing supply, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and create challenges for new hires. The stagnation in total nonfarm employment growth, with a mere 0.01% year-over-year change, raises questions about the broader health of the labor market.

Atlanta offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and access to a deep professional talent pool, with a strong office and professional worker share. However, the primary risk is the potential erosion of its affordability advantage due to a rapidly tightening housing market, which could increase labor costs and make it harder to attract new talent.

Memphis

Memphis

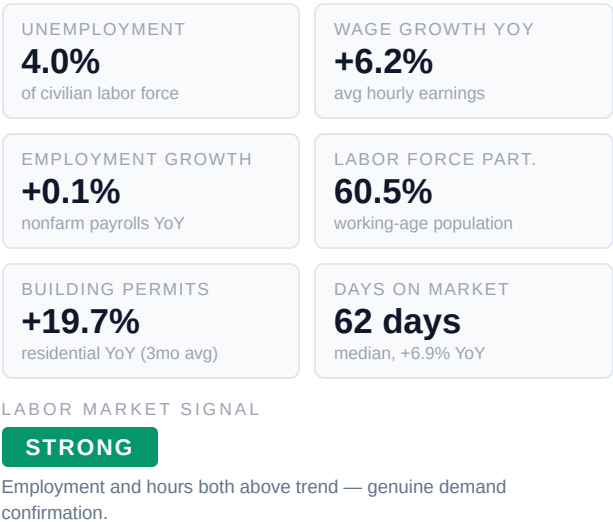
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
56.1th percentile
Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns a B+ grade, driven by its above-average economic performance, with a low unemployment rate of 4.00% and modest nonfarm employment growth of +0.06% YoY. The city's cost advantage, with a cost of living composite score of 0.48, ranking it among the most affordable metros, combined with solid wage growth of +6.16% YoY, creates a positive environment for consumer spending and business operations.

However, beneath the surface, tensions emerge. Memphis faces a critically low labor force participation rate of 60.48%, posing a significant structural constraint for businesses considering expansion or relocation. The city's housing market is experiencing a slowdown, with days on market increasing by +6.9% YoY to 62 days, indicating a stabilizing force rather than a warning sign, given the strong employment growth and rising building permits.

Memphis offers businesses an attractive combination of affordability, solid wage growth, and a healthy labor market expansion. However, the primary risk lies in the city's low labor force participation rate and limited professional workforce, which may constrain talent attraction and business growth.

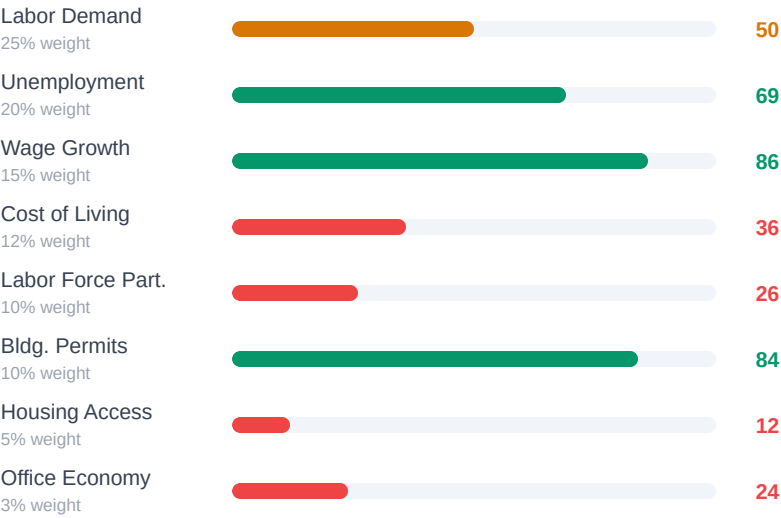
Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

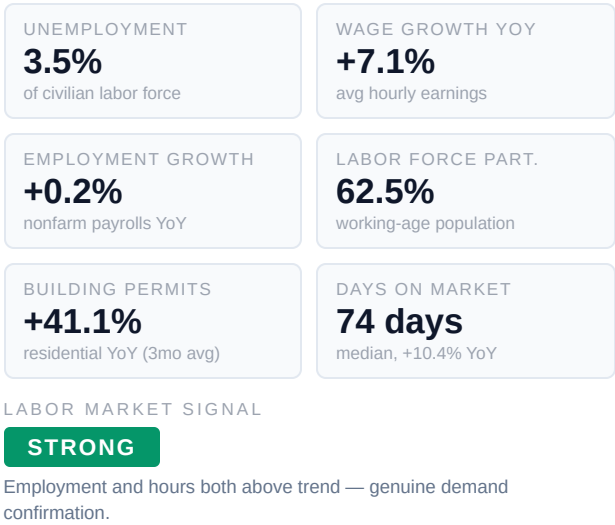
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
55.9th percentile
Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Miami's economy earns a B+ grade, driven by its strong performance, with a low unemployment rate of 3.50% and rapid wage growth of 7.12% year-over-year, indicating a constructive labor market. However, the city's labor force participation rate of 62.53% suggests a shallow labor pool, which may limit its ability to attract and retain talent.

The housing market presents a mixed picture, with building permits surging 41.11% year-over-year, but the days on market have increased by 10.4% year-over-year, with homes taking an average of 74 days to sell. This signals a slowing market, despite strong employment growth and rising permits. The cost of living, at 3.31, is a consideration for businesses looking to attract talent, particularly given the rapid wage growth.

Miami offers businesses a dynamic labor market with rising wages and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for talent and investment. However, the primary risk lies in the city's ability to balance its above-average cost of living with the need to attract and retain top talent, potentially requiring wage premiums to remain competitive.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

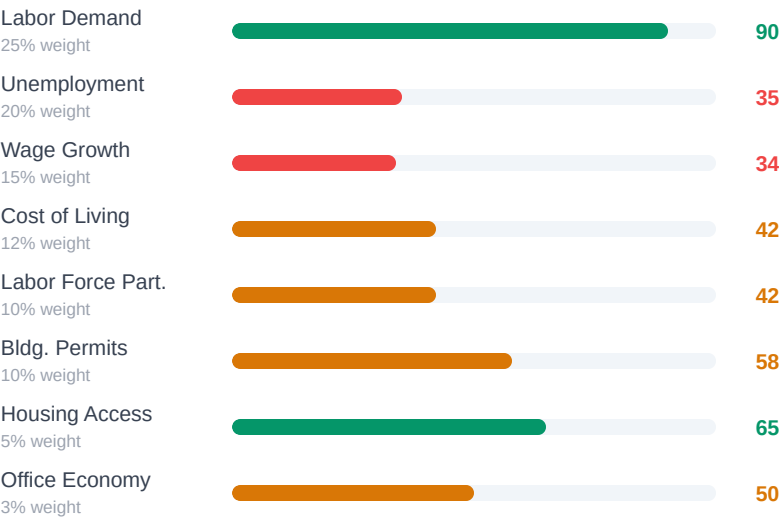
B

AVERAGE

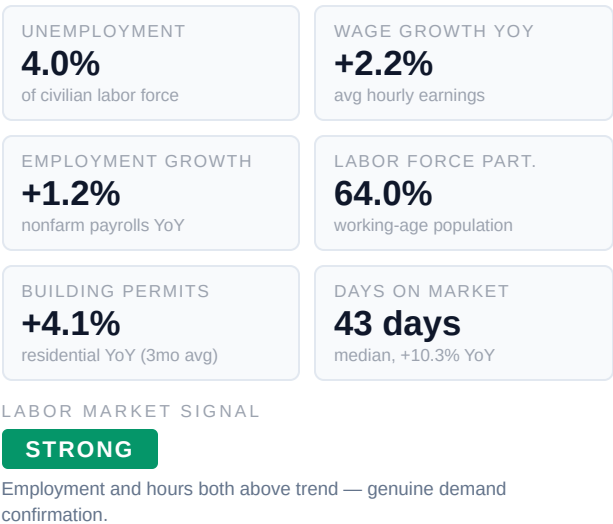
54.3th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Philadelphia's economy earns a grade of B, or 54.3rd percentile out of 50 US metros, with a top-tier nonfarm employment growth of +1.16% YoY, signaling an economically expanding market. However, this growth is juxtaposed with an elevated unemployment rate of 4.00%, indicating labor market slack and potentially weakened local consumer demand. Sluggish wage growth of +2.21% YoY implies a lower cost environment for employers, but may also signal weak worker bargaining power or softening demand.

The housing market shows a nuanced story, with days on market increasing by 10.3% YoY to an average of 43 days, indicating a moderate buyer advantage. This slowing market, combined with strong employment growth, suggests a healthy normalization, where buyers gain negotiating room and affordability pressure moderates. However, the city's below-average wage growth and elevated unemployment rate raise questions about the sustainability of this trend.

Philadelphia offers a dynamic and expanding economy, with rapid job creation and a relatively low-cost environment. However, labor market slack and sluggish wage growth pose a primary risk, potentially impacting the long-term sustainability of the city's economic momentum.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

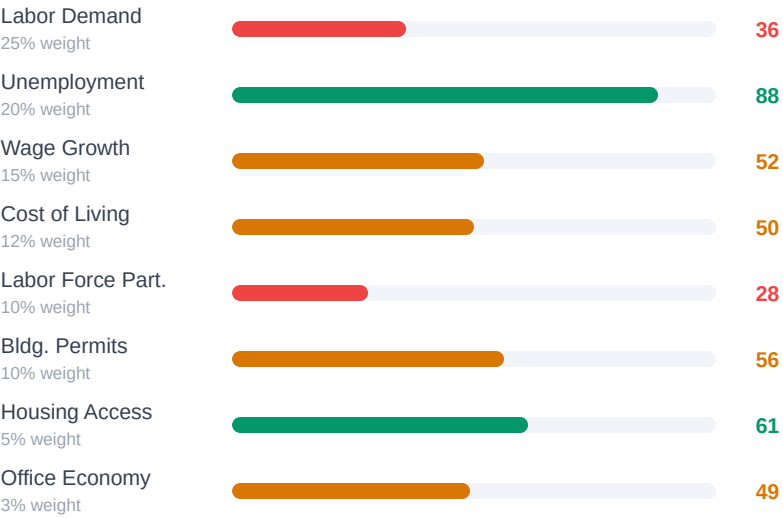
B

AVERAGE

53.3th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Louisville's economy earns a grade of B, or 53rd percentile out of 50 US metros, with a tight labor market and limited availability of workers. The city's exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.10% indicates significant hiring competition and worker leverage. However, this is paired with a below-average labor force participation rate of 62.74%, suggesting a shallow labor pool.

The interplay between these metrics reveals key tensions in the market. The low unemployment rate is offset by weak labor force participation and slow nonfarm employment growth of -0.06%, signaling economic deceleration. The housing market also shows signs of slowing demand, with days on market increasing by 9.8% year-over-year to an average of 45 days.

In summary, Louisville presents businesses with a unique challenge, with a tight labor market and slow employment growth. The primary risk is demand erosion, driven by weak employment growth and a slowing housing market, which may impact the city's long-term economic viability.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B

AVERAGE

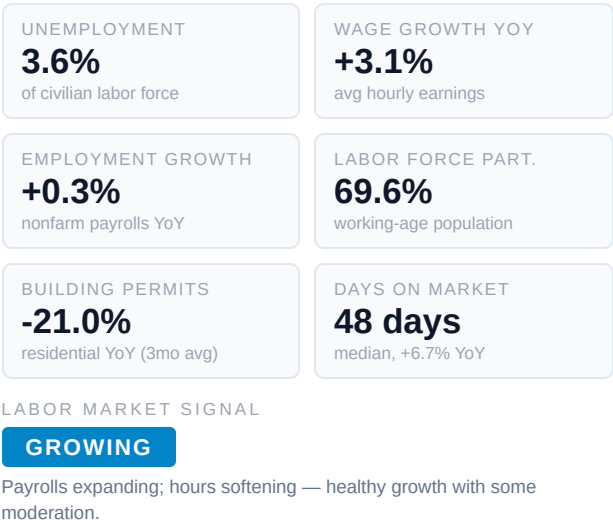
53.0th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Dallas's strong labor market, with a 69.61% labor force participation rate, makes it an attractive location for businesses. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.43 also indicates it is one of the most affordable metros, offering a significant cost advantage for businesses.

However, the housing market presents a challenge, with a sharp decline in building permits of -20.96% year-over-year. This, combined with a 6.7% year-over-year increase in days on market, averaging 48 days, suggests a genuine demand deterioration, which could impact workforce attraction and affordability in the long run.

Dallas offers a unique combination of a deep labor pool and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the city's struggling housing supply growth poses a risk, which could lead to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors in their location decision.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

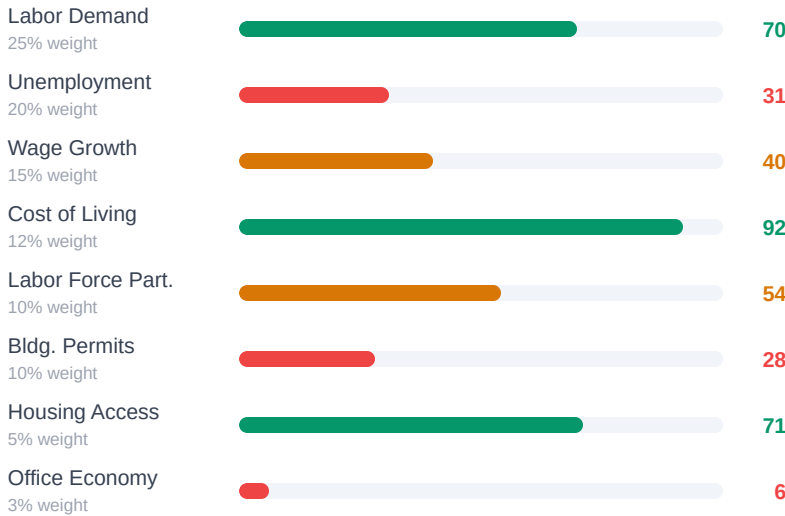
B

AVERAGE

52.6th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-12.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

50 days

median, +11.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Houston's economy earns a B grade, ranking 52.6th out of 50 US metros, driven by above-average nonfarm employment growth of +0.43% YoY. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.19 indicates it is among the most affordable metros, but a low office and professional worker share, ranking 6th percentile, constrains knowledge-economy businesses.

A key tension in the data is the combination of strong employment growth with sharply declining building permits, down 12.89% YoY, suggesting a housing supply squeeze is building. This could erode the city's affordability advantage and make it harder to attract workers. The days on market have increased by 11.1% YoY, with homes now taking an average of 50 days to sell, indicating a moderating housing market.

Houston offers businesses a unique combination of strong employment growth and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and cost management. However, the primary risk is a potential housing supply squeeze, which could undermine the city's affordability advantage and create challenges for workforce attraction and retention.

Kansas City

Kansas City

B

AVERAGE

52.6th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City's economy earns a grade of B, or 52.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a low unemployment rate of 3.50% and a high labor force participation rate of 67.91%. However, this is juxtaposed with a concerning -0.31% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, signaling a contraction in the job market.

The city's wage growth at +6.80% year-over-year is driven by a mix shift towards higher-paying industries, rather than broad labor market health. This, combined with a highly affordable cost of living, may indicate that the affordability advantage is eroding as demand outpaces housing supply. Homes are selling in fewer days than last year, averaging just 45 days on market, further exacerbating the issue.

Kansas City offers businesses a unique combination of a deep labor pool and an affordable cost of living, but the primary risk lies in the stagnant job market and rising labor costs. As a business location, Kansas City presents a trade-off between accessing a talented workforce at a lower cost of living and navigating the challenges of a slowing job market and competitive housing environment.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

B

AVERAGE

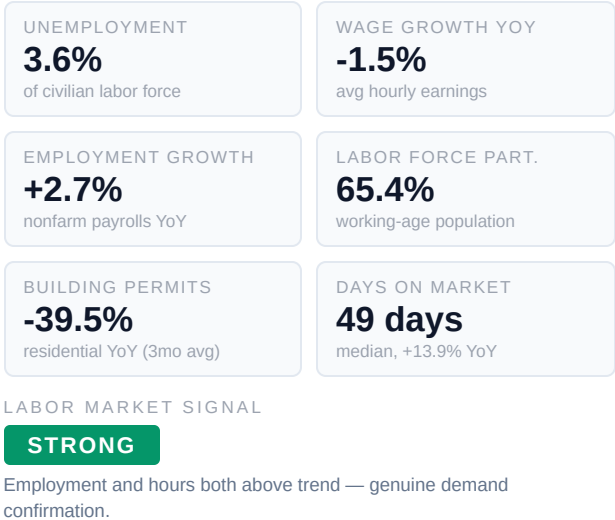
52.2th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Charlotte's economy is driven by rapid job creation, with nonfarm employment growth at 2.69% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier. This momentum is supported by a deep professional talent pool, as evidenced by its 94th percentile ranking for office and professional worker share. However, this growth is juxtaposed with stagnant wages, as hourly earnings have declined by 1.52% year-over-year, a bottom-tier performance.

The city's housing market is characterized by a supply squeeze, with building permits declining sharply by 39.50% year-over-year. Homes now take an average of 49 days to sell, with days on market increasing by 13.9% year-over-year. This slowing market, combined with the decline in building permits, suggests a risk of demand erosion, particularly given the strong employment growth.

Charlotte offers a dynamic and expanding market with a talented workforce, but the primary risk lies in the potential for a housing supply squeeze and its impact on affordability and workforce attraction. The city's inability to translate strong job growth into wage growth and its declining building permits are key caveats that decision-makers should consider when evaluating Charlotte as a business location.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

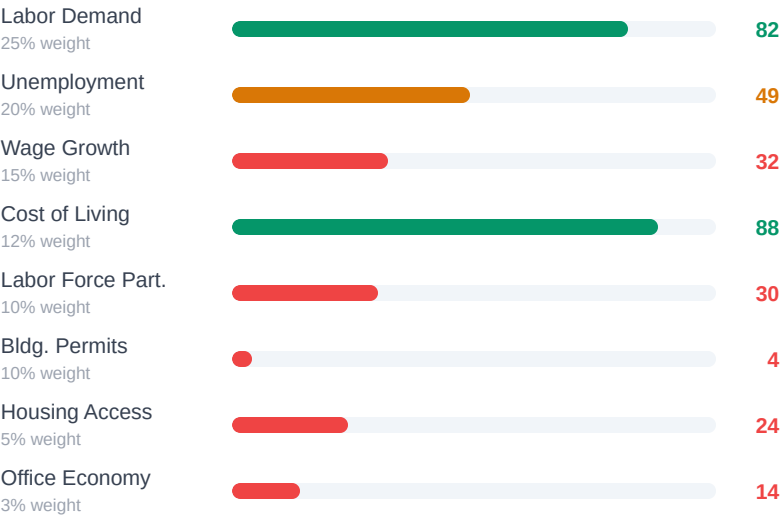
B

AVERAGE

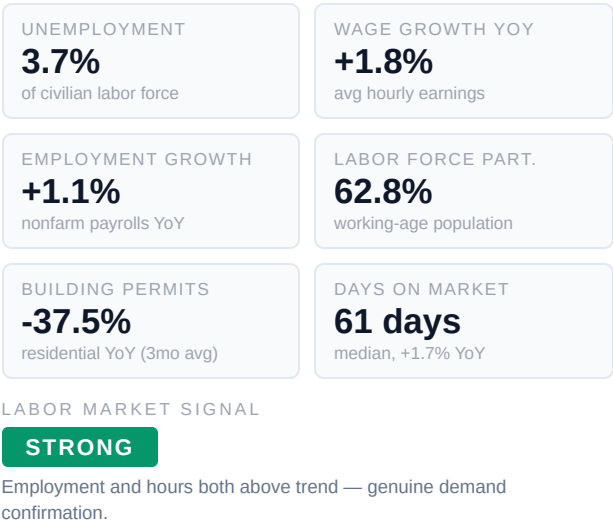
50.7th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Antonio's economy earns a grade of B, driven by a momentum-driven market with rapid job creation, with top-tier nonfarm employment growth of +1.09% YoY. However, this growth is accompanied by a shallow labor pool, with labor force participation at 62.78%, indicating that the workforce itself may be aging out or withdrawing.

The city's extremely affordable cost of living, with a composite score of 1.33, ranking it among the most affordable metros in the dataset, is a significant strength. However, the housing market is experiencing a sharp decline in building permits, down 37.55% YoY, which could lead to a housing supply squeeze and affordability stress. Additionally, the days on market are increasing by 1.7% YoY, with homes taking an average of 61 days to sell, indicating a slowing market.

San Antonio offers businesses a highly affordable cost of living and a rapidly expanding job market, making it an attractive location for companies looking to reduce costs and tap into a growing workforce. However, the primary risk is the potential for a housing supply squeeze and affordability stress, which could erode the city's cost advantage and make it harder to attract and retain talent.

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B

AVERAGE

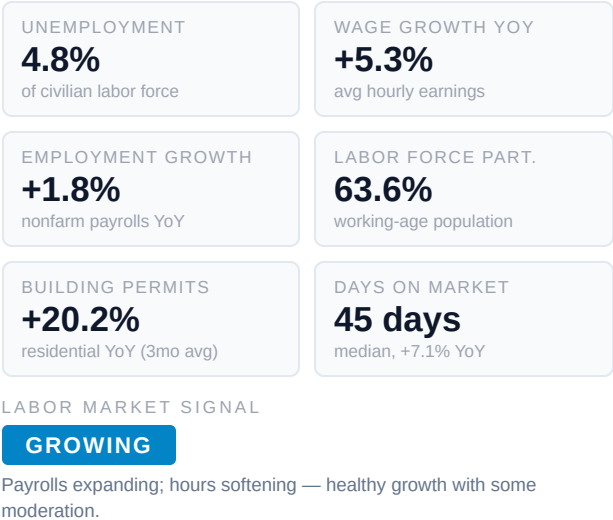
50.1th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim earns a B grade, reflecting its average standing among 50 US metros, with a notable weakness: a 4.80% unemployment rate, indicating severe labor market weakness and flagging consumer spending risk. However, rapid job creation, with a 1.83% year-over-year increase in nonfarm employment growth, signals an economically expanding market.

The city's wage growth of 5.33% year-over-year suggests positive consumer spending, but this is tempered by a 5.59 cost of living composite score, making it among the most expensive metros, potentially limiting real purchasing power gains. The low professional and office worker concentration, ranking in the 8th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim offers a business environment with rapid job creation and solid wage growth, but it comes with the primary risk of a high cost of living, which may constrain talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. The city's ability to attract and retain professionals will be a crucial factor in its economic trajectory, making it essential for businesses to carefully weigh these factors in their location decision.

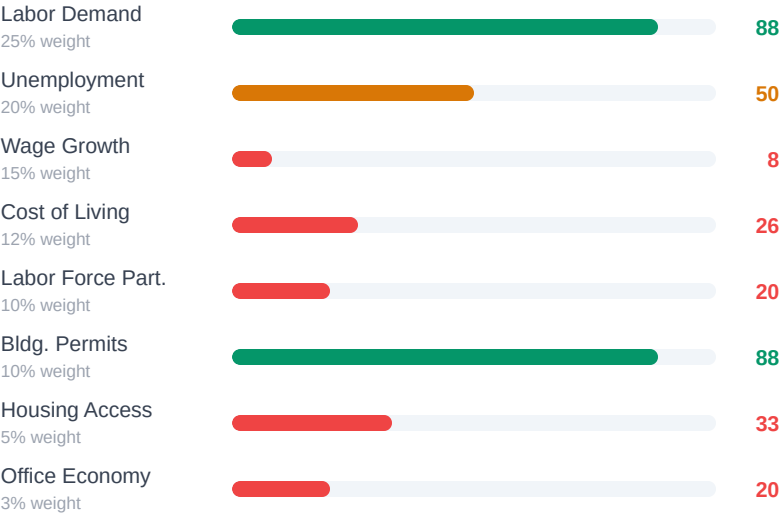
Birmingham

Birmingham

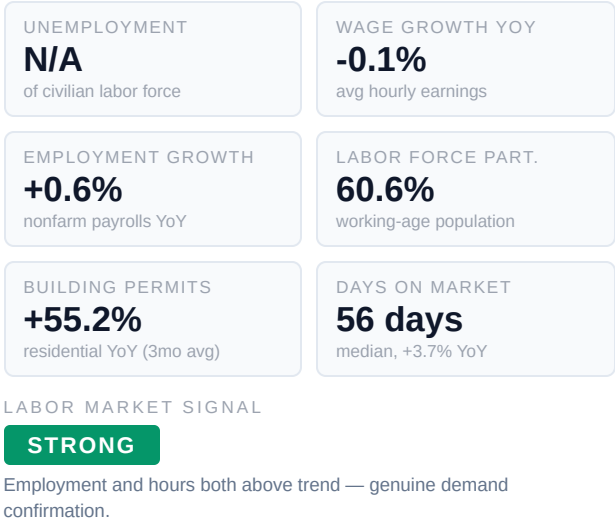
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.4th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham's economic character is defined by its strong job creation, with nonfarm employment growth at +0.61% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier, driven by an aggressive expansion in housing supply, with a +55.25% year-over-year increase in building permits, also in the top tier.

The city's economic narrative is nuanced by conflicting signals. While rapid job growth and increasing housing supply suggest a thriving market, stagnant wage growth, with hourly earnings declining by -0.12% year-over-year, raises concerns about the market's sustainability. The cost of living is above average, with a composite score of 3.72, necessitating wage premiums to attract talent. The housing market is also showing signs of normalization, with days on market increasing by 3.7% year-over-year to 56 days, indicating a moderating pace.

Birmingham offers businesses a dynamic and expanding market, with strong job growth and increasing housing supply, but the primary risk lies in stagnant wage growth and above-average cost of living, which may erode consumer spending power and necessitate higher labor costs to attract and retain talent.

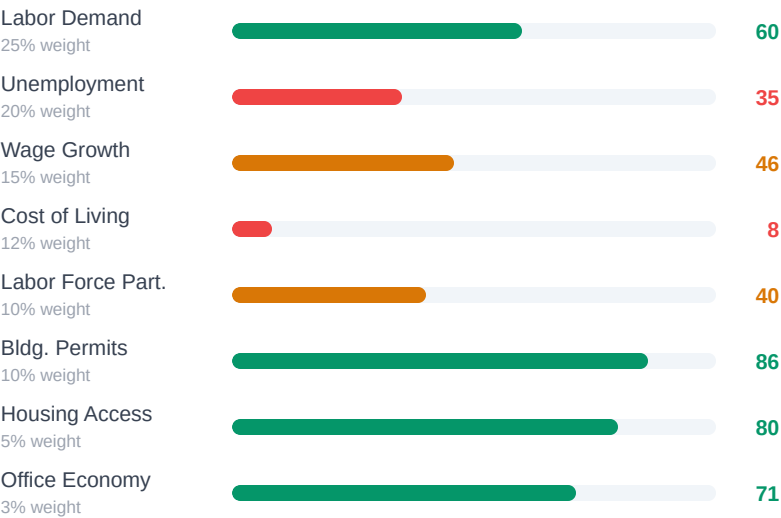
Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

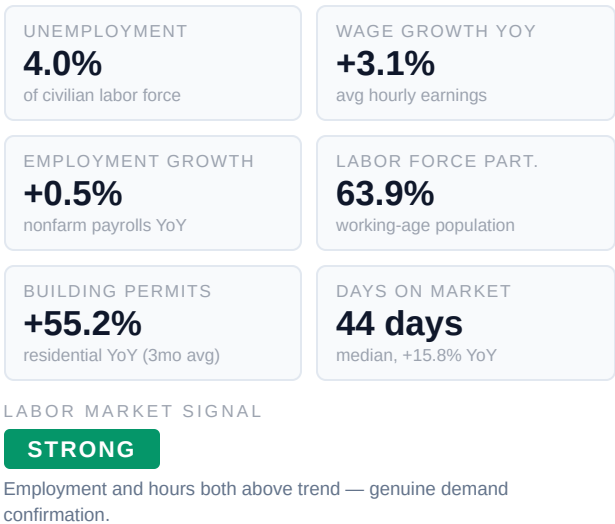
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.5th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood earns a B- grade, with a below-average economic performance marked by a 4.00% unemployment rate, indicating labor market slack that may weaken local consumer demand. However, the +0.51% nonfarm employment growth YoY suggests a healthy expansion, creating jobs. This tension defines the city's economic character, making it a complex market for businesses to navigate.

The city's composite cost of living score of 5.56 ranks it in the bottom tier, making it one of the more expensive metros. This high cost of living constrains talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. However, the +55.17% growth in building permits YoY and the +15.8% increase in days on market YoY, with an average of 44 days, suggest a moderating housing market that could give buyers more negotiating room.

Grand Rapids offers businesses a unique combination of labor market slack and job growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire. However, the high cost of living poses a significant risk, potentially limiting the city's appeal to businesses that rely on affordable talent and consumer spending power.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

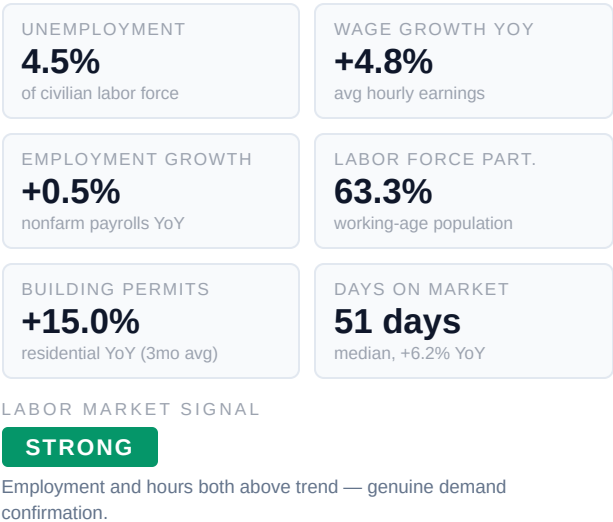
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.2th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

New York's economy earns a below-average overall grade of 48.2nd percentile, driven by a mix of strengths and weaknesses. The city's nonfarm employment growth of +0.48% YoY and wage growth of +4.84% YoY are notable bright spots, indicating a healthy expansion and solid consumer spending power.

The tension between New York's strong job market and its high cost of living is a key consideration. The city's above-average office and professional worker share is a mild positive for office-dependent businesses, but the elevated cost of living poses a significant constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. The housing market, with building permits growing at +14.97% YoY, is keeping pace with demand, but the days on market are increasing by +6.2% YoY, indicating a stabilizing force.

Ultimately, New York offers businesses a strong job market with solid wage growth, but at a high cost. The primary risk is the city's extremely high cost of living, which may limit the appeal to businesses and consumers alike, and could potentially weaken local consumer demand due to the labor market slack signaled by the elevated unemployment rate of 4.50%.

St. Louis

St. Louis

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.1th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns a B- grade, ranking 47th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a low unemployment rate of 3.50% and above-average labor force participation of 65.27%, indicating a healthy and constructive labor market. However, stagnant wage growth of +0.66% YoY raises concerns about consumer spending power and the overall vitality of the local economy.

The city's affordable cost of living, with a composite score of 3.50, contrasts with the slowing housing market, where homes are taking 17.9% more days to sell than last year, with an average of 46 days on market. This slowdown may indicate a normalization of the market, providing buyers with more negotiating room, or it could signal demand erosion due to economic softness. The decline in building permits by 6.99% YoY suggests the latter scenario is more likely, as it indicates a lack of supply response to meet demand.

St. Louis offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a stable labor market, but the primary risk lies in the city's sluggish wage growth and potentially weakening housing market. As a business location, St. Louis presents a mixed opportunity, where companies must balance the benefits of a low-cost environment with the potential risks of a softening local economy.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.8th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		64
Unemployment 20% weight		45
Wage Growth 15% weight		26
Cost of Living 12% weight		10
Labor Force Part. 10% weight		86
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		26
Housing Access 5% weight		63
Office Economy 3% weight		78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.4% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. 68.5% working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS -15.0% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 30 days median, +20.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Boston's economy is marked by a mix of strengths and weaknesses, earning a below-average overall grade of 46.8th percentile. The city's labor force participation rate of 68.47% stands out as a top-tier advantage, indicating a deep and engaged labor pool. However, this is offset by a cost of living composite score of 5.25, making it one of the most expensive metros in the country.

The city's housing market is complex, with days on market increasing by 20% year-over-year to an average of 30 days, suggesting a slowing market. Below-average building permit growth of -14.97% year-over-year indicates a potential tightening of housing supply. Sluggish wage growth of +1.42% year-over-year and a high cost of living raise concerns about the sustainability of demand in the housing market.

Boston offers businesses a highly engaged and skilled labor force, but at a significant cost. The primary risk for businesses considering location in Boston is the high cost of living, which may erode real consumer spending power and talent acquisition capabilities.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

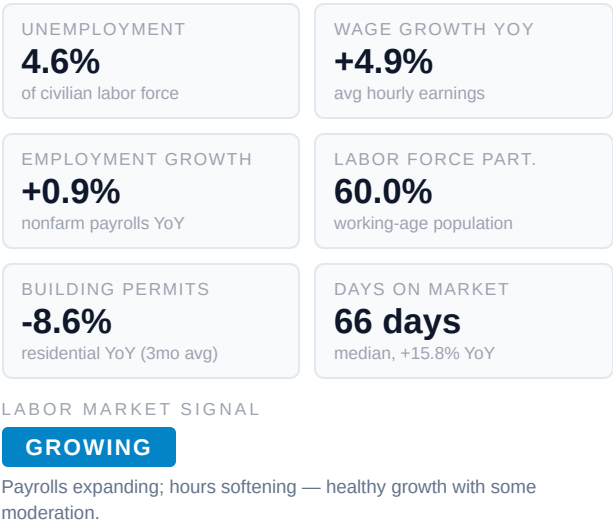
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.7th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Tampa's economic character is defined by its severe labor market weaknesses, with an unemployment rate of 4.60% and a critically low labor force participation rate of 59.95%, making it a challenging location for businesses and individuals. However, the city's cost of living composite score of 1.83 indicates a below-average cost of living, making it an attractive option for those seeking affordable living.

The city's nonfarm employment growth of +0.92% YoY and solid wage growth of +4.86% YoY suggest a healthy expansion, but the labor market challenges and slowing housing market, with days on market increasing by 15.8% YoY, raise concerns about the city's ability to sustain economic momentum. The affordable cost of living and above-average professional workforce concentration, ranking in the 76th percentile, are notable strengths that could attract businesses.

In summary, Tampa offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a growing economy, but the primary risk is the city's labor market weaknesses, including high unemployment and low labor force participation, which could constrain business expansion and relocation plans.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.3th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Seattle's economy earns a below-average grade of B- (45.3rd percentile), with a high unemployment rate of 5.00% and a potential risk to consumer spending. However, the city's strong workforce engagement, with a labor force participation rate of 68.24%, suggests a deep labor pool. Wage growth is also rising fast, with a 7.63% year-over-year increase, excellent for workers but potentially posing a cost pressure for employers.

Despite strong wage growth, total nonfarm employment growth is below average, at -0.15% year-over-year, suggesting economic deceleration. This tension raises questions about the sustainability of the wage growth, driven by a mix shift towards higher-paying jobs or broad labor market health. The city's housing market is also showing signs of slowing, with days on market increasing by 9.7% year-over-year, but the absolute level of 34 days still indicates a relatively fast market.

Seattle offers businesses a deep labor pool and strong wage growth, but labor market weakness and potential demand erosion pose a significant risk. The combination of high unemployment and slowing employment growth warrants careful consideration of the potential risks and challenges for businesses considering location decisions in Seattle.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

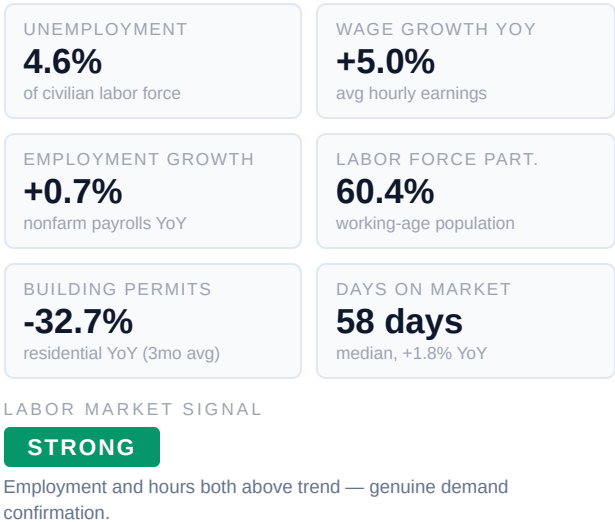
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.0th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville's economy lags, with a below-average overall grade of 45.0th percentile, driven by severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 4.60% and a labor force participation rate of 60.38%. Nonfarm employment growth, at 0.68%, is a bright spot, signaling a healthy expansion, while wage growth is solid, with hourly earnings rising 5.00% year-over-year.

Despite these positive trends, the city's housing market is a concern. Building permits are declining sharply, with a year-over-year drop of 32.70%, indicating a contraction in housing supply. Homes are taking 1.8% more days to sell, averaging 58 days, suggesting a slowing market and potentially eroding demand.

In summary, Jacksonville offers businesses an affordable cost of living, with a composite score of 1.44, and solid wage growth, but the primary risk is a tightening labor market and a slowing housing market. The city's severe labor market weakness and declining housing supply pose significant challenges for businesses, making it essential to carefully consider these factors in any location decision.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

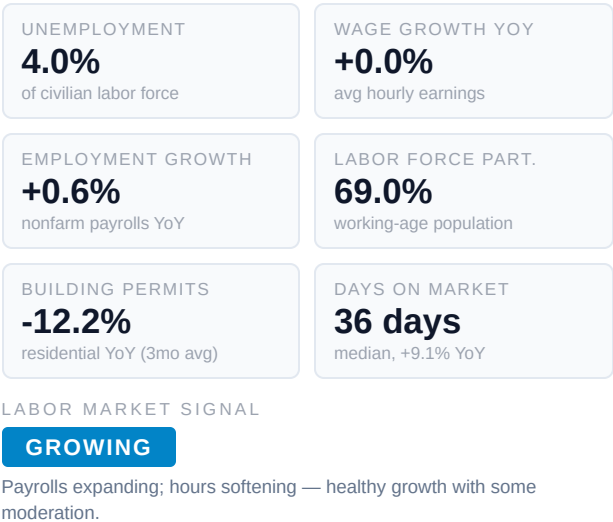
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.3th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area earns a B- grade, ranking 44th among 50 US metros, driven by a combination of labor market factors, including a top-tier labor force participation rate of 69.03% and a below-average unemployment rate of 4.00%. However, wage growth has been stagnant, with hourly earnings increasing by only 0.03% year-over-year, signaling potential softness in the market.

Despite the strong labor force participation, the data reveals tensions between different metrics. The sluggish wage growth and declining building permits, down 12.25% year-over-year, suggest a weakening demand for housing and potentially a slowing economy. The days on market have increased by 9.1% year-over-year, with homes now taking an average of 36 days to sell, indicating a moderating housing market.

Minneapolis offers a deep labor pool with high workforce engagement, making it an attractive location for businesses seeking to hire. However, the primary risk lies in the potential softening of local consumer demand due to stagnant wage growth and a slowing housing market, which may impact the overall economic momentum and affordability in the region.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

C+

POOR

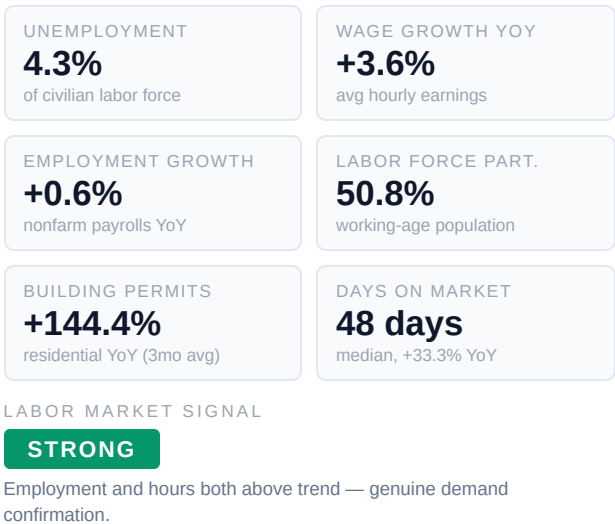
44.0th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Providence's struggling labor market and high cost of living define its economic character, with a labor force participation rate of 50.77% and an elevated unemployment rate of 4.30%, signaling labor market slack and potentially weakened local consumer demand. The city's cost of living composite score of 7.35 indicates it is among the most expensive metros, posing a meaningful constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

Despite these challenges, the city's housing market shows a more nuanced story. Building permits are up 144.37% year-over-year, indicating an aggressive expansion of housing supply, which could help moderate affordability pressures. However, homes are taking 33.3% more days to sell than last year, with an average of 48 days on market, suggesting a slowing market.

Providence offers a unique opportunity to capitalize on a growing housing supply, but the primary risk lies in the city's constrained labor market and high cost of living. As a business considering relocation or expansion, it is crucial to weigh the potential benefits of a growing housing market against the challenges posed by a limited workforce and expensive living costs.

Cleveland

Cleveland

C+

POOR

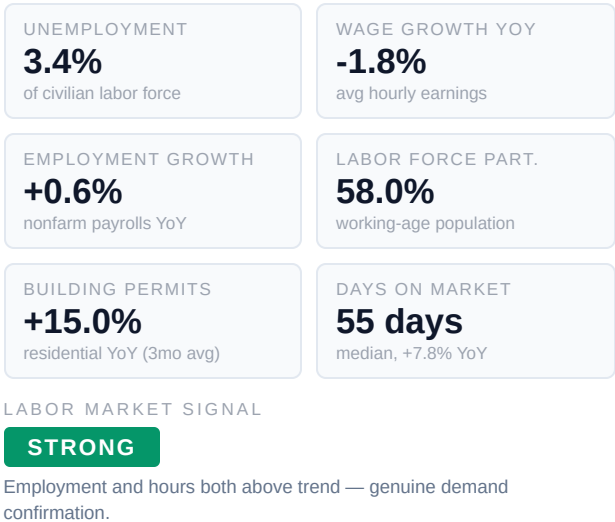
43.6th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland's economic character is defined by its 3.40% unemployment rate, a healthy labor market, but also a critically low labor force participation rate of 58.01%, indicating a shallow pool of available workers. This combination creates a tension, as the tight headline rate may mask a shrinking workforce rather than just low layoffs.

The high cost of living, with a composite score of 5.00, is a significant constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. The above-average share of office and professional workers, ranking in the 74th percentile, is a mild positive, but it is overshadowed by the more pressing issues of labor force participation and cost of living.

Cleveland offers a business a relatively low-unemployment environment, but with significant structural constraints, including a shallow labor pool and high cost of living. The primary risk for businesses considering relocation or expansion in Cleveland is the limited availability of workers, which may hinder growth and talent acquisition, making it essential to carefully weigh these factors in any location decision.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

C+

POOR

39.7th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Washington D.C. is a city with a struggling labor market, characterized by a bottom-tier nonfarm employment growth of -1.63% year-over-year, resulting in job losses and economic contraction. This is further exacerbated by sluggish wage growth of +1.37% year-over-year, which is below average and indicates weak worker bargaining power or softening demand. The city's high labor force participation rate of 67.37% suggests a large available workforce.

The housing market is also experiencing tensions, with days on market increasing by 25% year-over-year, and homes taking an average of 30 days to sell. This indicates a slowing market, which could be a sign of demand erosion, particularly given the weak employment growth and average building permits. The cost of living composite score of 2.06, above average, suggests a mild cost advantage, but this may be offset by the slowing labor market.

Washington D.C. offers a business a large available workforce and a mild cost advantage, but the primary risk is the slowing labor market and potential demand erosion. The city's economic contraction and sluggish wage growth make it a challenging location for businesses looking to expand or relocate, and decision-makers should carefully consider these factors before making a decision.

Fresno

Fresno

C+

POOR

39.4th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno's economy is marked by a dismal 8.20% unemployment rate and a lackluster 0.22% annual growth in nonfarm employment, indicating a stagnant job market. Despite this, hourly earnings have increased by 7.60% year-over-year, a top-tier metric suggesting a shift towards higher-paying jobs.

Fresno's low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 4th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The city's aggressive building permit growth, up 61.97% year-over-year, could help alleviate affordability pressures, but the increasing days on market, currently at 51 days and rising 10.9% year-over-year, suggest a slowing market and potential demand erosion.

Fresno's business landscape is characterized by a relatively affordable cost of living and rapidly expanding housing supply, but its severe labor market challenges and low professional worker concentration pose significant risks. The primary caveat for businesses considering relocation to Fresno is the city's stagnant job market, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and hinder long-term growth prospects.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

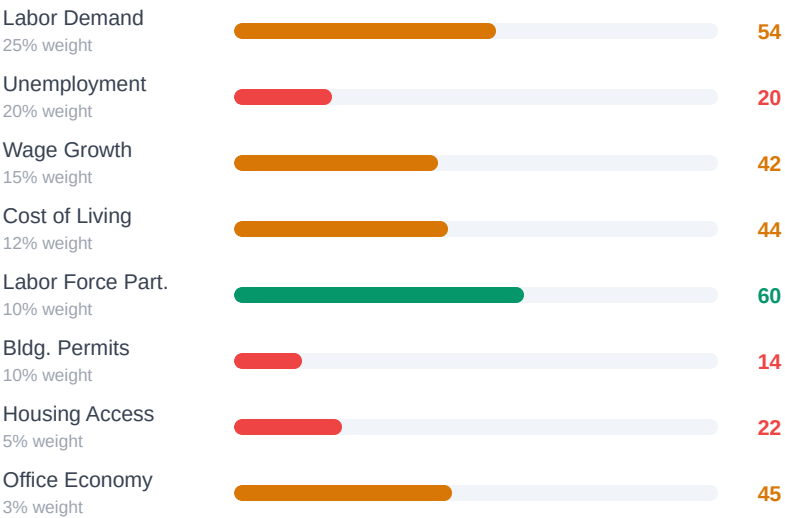
C+

POOR

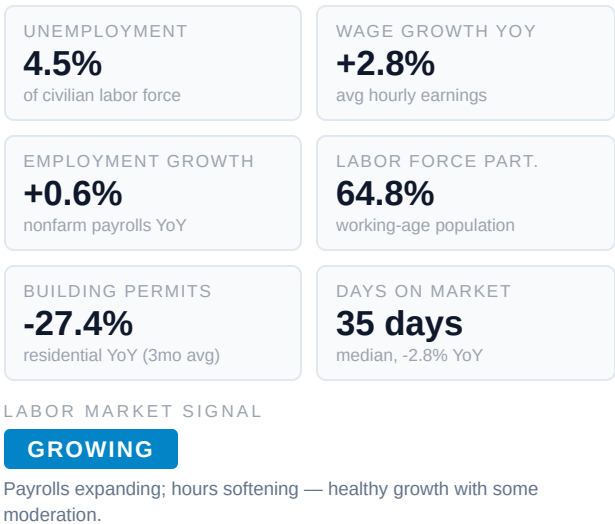
39.0th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Chicago's economic character is defined by a rapidly tightening housing market and labor market slack, with an unemployment rate of 4.50%. This labor market slack could make hiring easier, but also potentially weaken local consumer demand. Meanwhile, the housing market is extremely fast, with homes selling in just 35 days on average, a pace that is accelerating with a -2.8% year-over-year change. The sharp decline in building permits, down 27.41% year-over-year, raises concerns about the sustainability of this housing market strength. This contraction in housing supply, combined with the rapid pace of home sales, may be creating a thin-supply illusion rather than genuine demand strength. The labor force participation rate, at 64.75%, is a mild positive, but it is not enough to offset the concerns about housing supply and labor market slack.

Chicago offers a business a labor market with some slack, which could facilitate hiring, but also poses significant risks in terms of housing affordability and workforce attraction. The rapidly tightening housing market could become a major obstacle to attracting and retaining talent, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider the potential implications of this dynamic on their operations and growth prospects.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

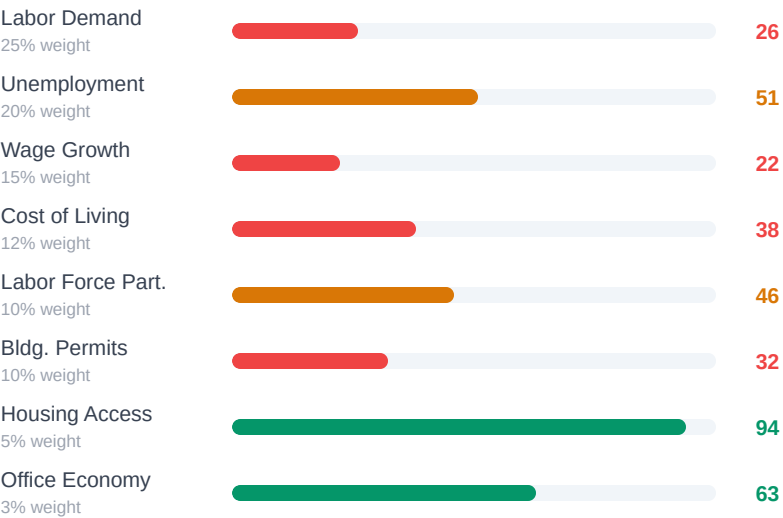
C+

POOR

39.0th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Baltimore's economic growth is stagnant, with a nonfarm employment growth rate of -0.14% year-over-year, and below-average wage growth of +1.22% year-over-year, indicating a decelerating job market. This slow pace of economic expansion is also reflected in the city's housing market, where days on market have increased by 27.6% year-over-year, resulting in an average of 37 days on market, signaling a slowing market.

The city's cost of living composite score of 3.21, indicating an above-average cost of living, adds to the complexity of the narrative. Baltimore boasts an above-average share of office and professional workers, ranking in the 63rd percentile, but this positive aspect is tempered by the city's struggling job market and softening housing demand. The decline in building permits by 11.14% year-over-year further suggests that the city's housing supply is not responding to the slowing demand, potentially leading to a tightening of the market and increased affordability concerns.

In summary, Baltimore's sluggish economic growth and softening demand pose significant risks, making it challenging to attract and retain talent. While the city offers a relatively low-cost labor environment, businesses must consider the potential for demand erosion, which could undermine the city's economic stability.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

C+

POOR

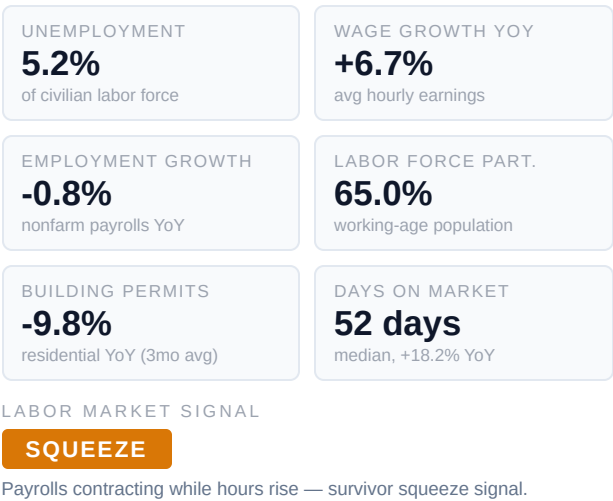
39.0th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Las Vegas' economic character is defined by its struggling labor market, with a 5.20% unemployment rate and -0.76% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, indicating severe labor market weakness and job losses. Hourly earnings have risen 6.71% year-over-year, suggesting that while jobs may be scarce, those that exist are becoming more lucrative. This combination of metrics paints a picture of a city with a challenged labor market, but one where employers may face cost pressures due to rising wages.

The tension between strong wage growth and weak employment growth is a key nuance in the Las Vegas market. Homes take an average of 52 days to sell, with this duration increasing by 18.2% year-over-year, suggesting a slowing housing market. This slowdown, combined with weak employment growth and average building permits, indicates that the city's economic momentum may be eroding.

The bottom line is that Las Vegas offers a complex and challenging market for businesses, with a high risk of labor market instability and slowing economic momentum. Rising wages may attract skilled workers, but the city's overall economic weaknesses, including high unemployment and slowing employment growth, pose a significant caveat for businesses considering location decisions.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

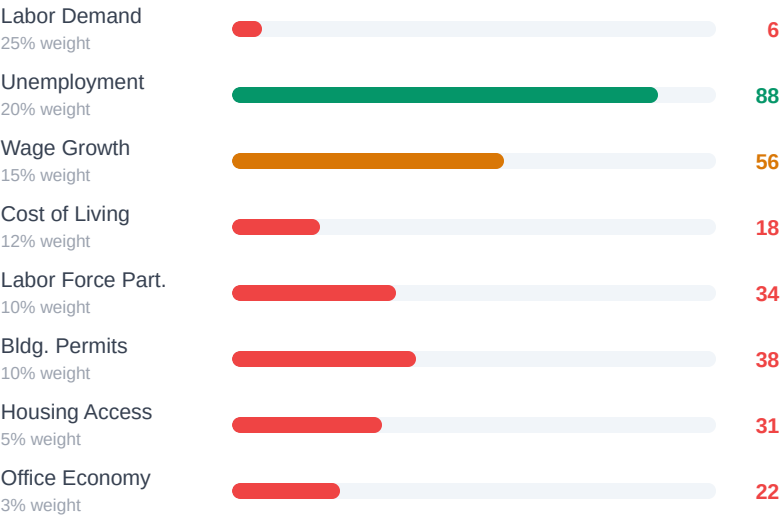
C+

POOR

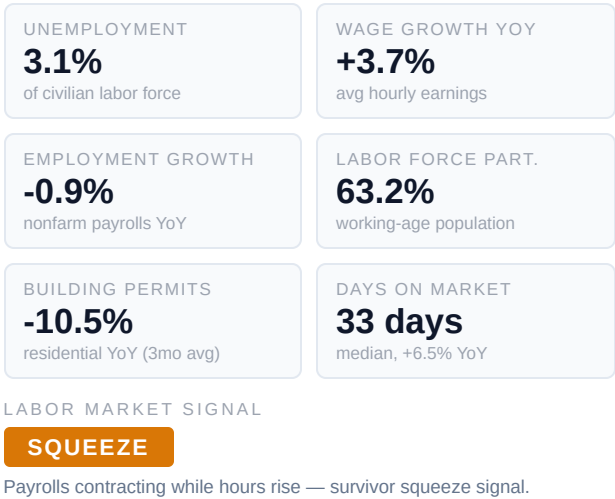
39.0th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Milwaukee's economic character is defined by a tight labor market, with an unemployment rate of 3.10%, and a contractionary employment growth story, with nonfarm employment declining by 0.91% year-over-year, resulting in a C+ grade. This tension is exacerbated by a shallow labor pool, with a labor force participation rate of 63.19%, indicating that the workforce may be aging out or withdrawing.

The housing market tells a story of conflicting trends, with a cost of living composite score of 4.27, making it one of the most expensive metros. Despite this, homes are taking longer to sell, with days on market increasing by 6.5% year-over-year to an average of 33 days. This slowdown may be a sign of demand erosion, particularly given the weak employment growth and declining building permits.

In summary, Milwaukee offers businesses a highly competitive labor market, but with significant constraints on talent availability and affordability. The primary risk for businesses locating in Milwaukee is the potential for demand erosion and a shrinking workforce, which could limit growth and expansion opportunities.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

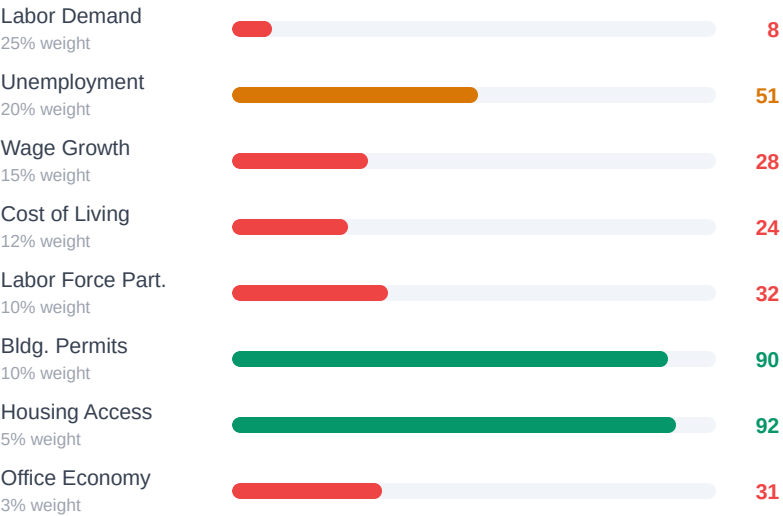
C

VERY POOR

37.0th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati's economic character is defined by its struggling labor market, earning it a grade of C and ranking 37th out of 50 US metros. The city's nonfarm employment growth is a concerning -0.52% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier, and wage growth is a lackluster +1.53% year-over-year, below average. This contraction story is further complicated by a labor force participation rate of 63.08%, indicating a shallow labor pool.

The housing market tells a conflicting story, with building permits surging +57.47% year-over-year, a top-tier performance, and days on market increasing by +21.6% year-over-year, with homes taking an average of 45 days to sell. However, this increase in days on market, combined with weak employment growth, suggests a demand erosion scenario, where fewer qualified buyers are in the market due to economic softness.

Cincinnati offers a business a relatively affordable cost of living composite of 3.72, but the primary risk is a weakening labor market, which may constrain growth and talent acquisition. The city's economic softness, particularly in employment growth, is a significant caveat that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Cincinnati as a business location.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

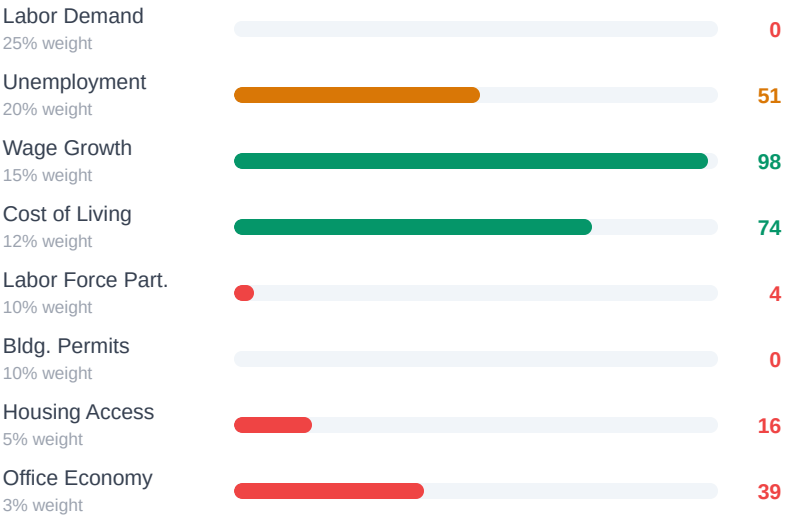
C

VERY POOR

36.2th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area earns a C grade, ranking 36.2nd out of 50 US metros, with a labor market characterized by critically low participation (58.99% of working-age adults employed or actively looking for work) and a -1.34% year-over-year contraction in total nonfarm employment. Despite this, hourly earnings have risen by 10.22% year-over-year, driven by a shift toward higher-paying jobs rather than broad labor market health.

The housing market is marked by scarcity, with building permits declining sharply by -46.79% year-over-year and homes selling quickly, with an average of 36 days on market and a -5.3% year-over-year change. This rapid pace of sales, combined with a below-average cost of living, suggests that the affordability advantage is eroding as demand outpaces housing supply.

The primary risk for businesses in this market is the scarcity of labor and housing, which may drive up costs and make it difficult to attract and retain talent. With the affordability advantage likely to be short-lived, businesses must carefully consider the long-term implications of locating in this market.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C

VERY POOR

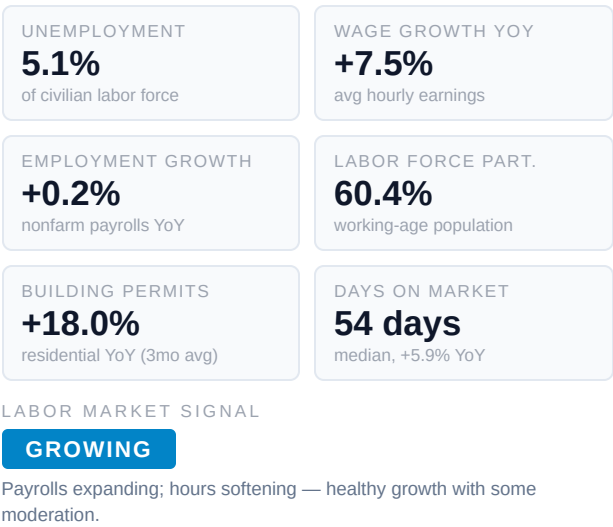
35.3th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area earns a C grade, ranking 35th among 50 US metros, driven by severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 5.10% and a low labor force participation rate of 60.37%. The area's nonfarm employment growth is stagnant, at +0.18% year-over-year, indicating a contraction story that dominates the city's economic narrative.

Wage growth in the area is a notable bright spot, with hourly earnings rising by +7.54% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier. However, this strong wage growth is at odds with the stagnant employment picture, suggesting that wages may be rising due to a mix shift toward higher-paying jobs rather than broad labor market health. The area's low concentration of office and professional workers, ranking 16th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

The housing market also tells a nuanced story, with building permits growing at an above-average rate of +18.04% year-over-year, but days on market increasing by +5.9% year-over-year, indicating a slowing market. Overall, Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario offers a complex and challenging economic environment, with strong wage growth but significant labor market weaknesses, posing a risk for businesses considering relocation to this area.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

C

VERY POOR

33.5th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area earns a C grade, ranking 33.5th out of 50 US metros, driven by severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 4.90% and nonfarm employment growth of -0.69% year-over-year, indicating job losses and stagnation. The office and professional worker share is low, ranking 12th percentile, posing a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

Wage growth is solid at +4.78% year-over-year, supporting consumer spending, but the housing market tells a conflicting story. Homes sell faster than most metros, at an average of 49 days on market, and a year-over-year decrease of -3.9%. This speed is likely driven by a supply contraction, given the -18.14% year-over-year decline in building permits.

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro's labor market weaknesses and constrained housing supply pose significant risks for businesses, making it challenging to attract and retain talent. While the cost of living composite is above average, the rapidly selling homes and weak job market raise concerns about affordability and workforce attraction.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

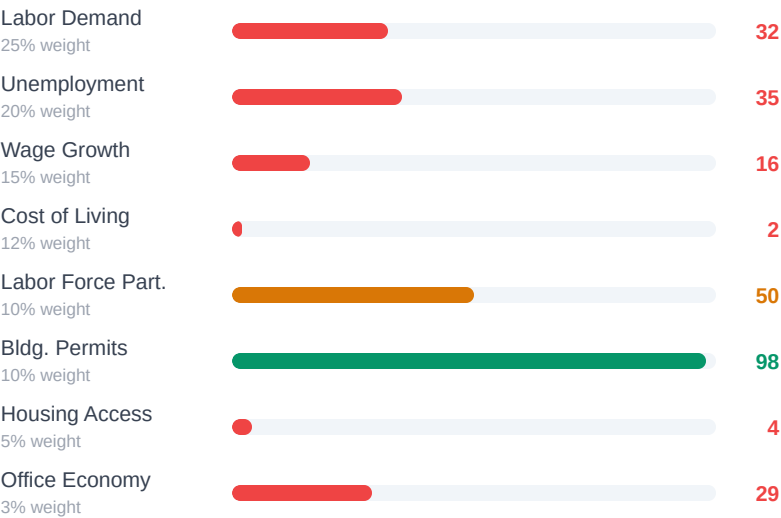
C

VERY POOR

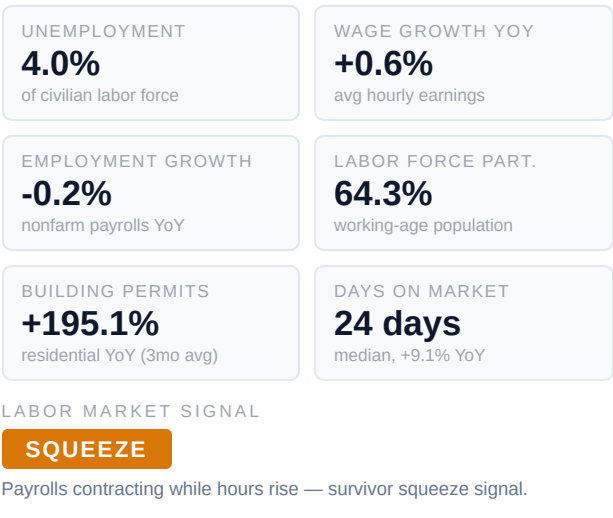
33.4th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Jose's overall economic grade of C, ranking 33.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, reflects a market with significant challenges, with an unemployment rate of 4.00% and below-average nonfarm employment growth of -0.16% YoY, indicating labor market slack and economic deceleration. Stagnant wage growth of +0.59% YoY suggests that workers have limited leverage, which could weaken local consumer demand.

The city's housing supply is expanding aggressively, with building permits up 195.09% YoY, which could eventually lead to improved affordability. However, the days on market are increasing by 9.1% YoY, with homes selling in just 24 days, indicating a still-competitive housing market. The city's cost of living composite score of 6.03, ranking in the bottom tier, poses a significant constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

San Jose offers a business a highly competitive but potentially softening housing market, with an expanding supply that could improve affordability in the long term. However, the primary risk is the city's high cost of living and weak employment growth, which could limit the availability of skilled workers and undermine consumer demand, making it a challenging location for businesses to thrive.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

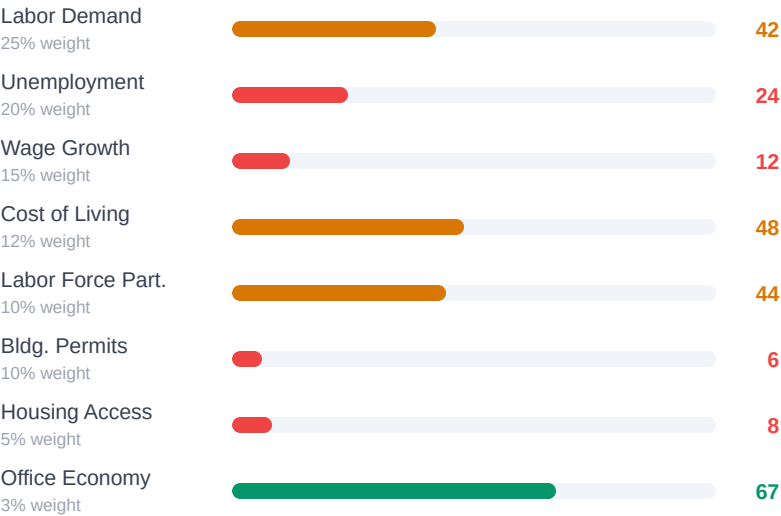
C-

CRITICAL

30.4th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Orlando's economy earns a C- grade, with a labor market exhibiting notable slack and a housing sector under pressure, characterized by a 4.40% unemployment rate and stagnant wage growth of +0.37% YoY, ranking in the bottom tier.

The housing market is experiencing a slowdown, with building permits plummeting by -35.64% YoY, and days on market increasing by +11.7% YoY, with homes taking an average of 67 days to sell, placing Orlando in the bottom tier for housing market speed. This scenario suggests demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization, given the lackluster employment growth of +0.24% YoY.

Orlando's elevated unemployment rate and stagnant wage growth pose significant challenges for businesses, while the slowing housing market and demand erosion could dampen consumer spending and overall economic vitality. The above-average share of office and professional workers, ranking in the 67th percentile, offers a mild positive for office-dependent businesses, but this is overshadowed by the broader economic and housing market concerns.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

C-

CRITICAL

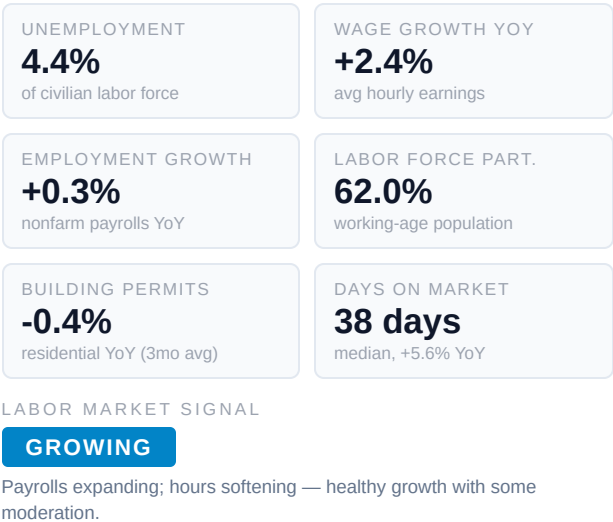
29.4th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Diego's sluggish labor market and high cost of living define its economic character, with a 4.40% unemployment rate and 62.01% labor force participation rate, indicating a shallow and stagnant labor pool. The city's nonfarm employment growth is a mere 0.35% year-over-year, reflecting economic deceleration.

The housing market is characterized by a 5.6% year-over-year increase in days on market to an average of 38 days, indicating a slowing pace and potentially softening demand. The low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 18th percentile, constrains knowledge-economy businesses.

San Diego's high cost of living and shallow labor pool make it challenging to attract and retain talent, posing a significant risk to businesses reliant on a skilled and abundant workforce. The city's sluggish labor market and softening demand may hinder business growth and expansion, making it a less desirable location.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

C-

CRITICAL

27.7th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.1%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+86.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

29 days

median, -6.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Francisco's economy earns a C- grade, marked by a declining labor market and a highly competitive housing market, with nonfarm employment growth declining by 0.52% year-over-year and wage growth stagnating at 0.49% year-over-year. The city's cost of living composite score of 5.79 indicates it is among the most expensive metros, constraining talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

The housing market is extremely competitive, with homes selling in just 29 days on average, and the market speeding up by 6.5% year-over-year. This fast-paced market poses a relocation challenge for new hires. However, building permits are increasing by 86.01% year-over-year, potentially signaling a expansion of the housing supply and alleviating some affordability pressures.

San Francisco offers a highly competitive and expensive market, with a declining labor market and a fast-paced housing market. The primary risk for businesses is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the high cost of living and competitive housing market, which could outweigh the benefits of locating in this city.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

D

EMERGENCY

21.8th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Detroit's economic landscape is marked by significant challenges, earning it an overall grade of D, ranking 21.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's labor market is particularly weak, with an unemployment rate of 4.70%, indicating a substantial portion of the workforce is without jobs. This is further exacerbated by stagnant wage growth, with a -1.13% year-over-year change, suggesting that even employed workers are not seeing meaningful increases in their earnings.

The city's labor force participation rate is below average at 61.27%, and nonfarm employment growth is sluggish at +0.01% year-over-year. The cost of living composite score of 4.08 suggests that Detroit is relatively affordable, but this advantage may be offset by the lack of job opportunities and stagnant wages. The decline in building permits, down 10.94% year-over-year, raises concerns about the city's ability to meet future housing demand, potentially leading to affordability issues.

Detroit presents a high-risk proposition for businesses, with a struggling labor market and limited economic growth opportunities. The primary caveat for businesses considering locating in Detroit is the potential for weak consumer spending and limited access to skilled labor, which could hinder their ability to grow and thrive in this market.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

D

EMERGENCY

21.1th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area earns a disappointing D grade, ranking 21st percentile out of 50 US metros, driven primarily by severe labor market weakness. With an unemployment rate of 4.80% and a labor force participation rate of 60.12%, the area's economic momentum is stalled.

The housing market is also struggling, with building permits declining at a rate of -15.51% year-over-year and days on market increasing by +8.3% year-over-year, indicating a slowing demand for housing. The low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 0th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

The area's relatively affordable cost of living, at 4.08, is overshadowed by significant labor market and housing market risks. Businesses considering this location should be aware of the potential for weak consumer spending and limited access to skilled workers, which could hinder growth and expansion efforts.